A free guide

A Professional's Guide to Getting Psychiatric Care in Chicago

Who does what, how to find someone, what it costs, how confidentiality works, and how to make your first appointment count. Written for busy people who would rather spend twenty minutes reading than six months guessing.

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1. Who does what

Most confusion starts here. These clinicians often work together, and the right first step depends on whether you want medication, therapy, testing, or a mix.

Clinician	What they do
Psychiatrist (MD or DO)	A physician specializing in psychiatry. Diagnoses and prescribes, and often focuses on complex cases and medication management.
Psychiatric nurse practitioner (PMHNP)	An advanced practice nurse with graduate training and board certification in psychiatry. Diagnoses and prescribes. In Illinois, newer nurse practitioners practice under a collaborative agreement with a physician.
Psychologist (PhD or PsyD)	Provides therapy and psychological testing, such as formal ADHD or learning evaluations. Most do not prescribe.
Therapist (LCPC, LCSW, LMFT)	Provides talk therapy, such as cognitive behavioral therapy. Does not prescribe.
Primary care clinician	Often the first stop for common depression and anxiety, and can refer you on when needed.

> **A useful rule of thumb:** for many common conditions, therapy and medication together work better than either alone. A good prescriber will ask whether you have a therapist, and a good therapist will tell you when a medication evaluation makes sense.

2. When it may be time to talk to someone

You don't need to be in crisis to deserve care. Consider an evaluation when:

- Low mood, worry, irritability, or poor sleep has lasted more than two weeks
- Your work, relationships, or health are starting to pay for it
- You're relying on alcohol, cannabis, or other substances to wind down or keep going
- Strategies that used to work, like exercise or time off, no longer help
- People close to you have said they're worried

High performers often wait the longest, because they keep functioning on the outside. Functioning is not the same as being well.

3. How to find care in Chicago

1. **Your insurance directory.** Filter for psychiatry or mental health, then call to confirm the clinician is taking new patients. Directories are often out of date.
2. **Your Employee Assistance Program (EAP).** Many employers offer a few free, confidential counseling sessions and referrals. Your employer gets usage counts, not your name or details.
3. **Your primary care clinician.** Ask for a referral, or whether they can start treatment while you wait.
4. **Psychology Today and similar directories.** Filter by insurance, specialty, telehealth, and whether the clinician prescribes.
5. **Hospital and university outpatient clinics.** Large Chicago health systems run outpatient psychiatry and therapy programs, sometimes with training clinics at lower cost.

Wait times for psychiatric care in Chicago can run weeks to months. Get on more than one waitlist, and ask about telehealth: Illinois-licensed clinicians can see you by video anywhere in the state.

4. What it costs and how to pay

Option	How it works
In-network	You pay a copay or coinsurance after your deductible. Usually the cheapest option, but often the longest wait.
Out-of-network	You pay the clinician, then submit a superbill (an itemized receipt) to your insurer. Many plans reimburse part of the cost after you meet an out-of-network deductible. Call your insurer and ask exactly what they reimburse for psychiatric visits.
Cash-pay	You pay the clinician directly and nothing goes to an insurer. Often shorter waits and longer visits, at a higher out-of-pocket cost.
HSA or FSA	Psychiatric visits and prescriptions are usually eligible expenses, which lets you pay with pre-tax dollars.

> **Your right to a Good Faith Estimate.** Under the federal No Surprises Act, if you pay cash or don't use insurance, clinicians must give you a written estimate of expected costs before your visit. If the bill comes in at least $400 higher, you can dispute it. Learn more at cms.gov/nosurprises.

5. Confidentiality, for people with careers to protect

Many professionals avoid care because they worry about who will find out. Here's what's generally true in Illinois:

- **Illinois law is strict.** The Illinois Mental Health and Developmental Disabilities Confidentiality Act protects mental health records more strongly than most states' laws. As a rule, records aren't released without your written consent.
- **Your employer doesn't see your records.** Using insurance doesn't send your diagnosis to your employer, though your insurer does receive it with each claim.
- **There are limits.** Clinicians may share information without consent in narrow situations, such as a serious and imminent risk of harm, suspected abuse, or a court order.
- **Licensed professionals:** many licensing applications ask about current impairment rather than past treatment. Read your board's actual questions, or ask a licensing attorney, before assuming that getting help puts your license at risk. Untreated illness is usually the bigger risk.

6. Questions to ask before you book

☐ Do you treat adults with concerns like mine?
☐ Do you prescribe, provide therapy, or both?
☐ How long are first visits and follow-ups, and how often will we meet?
☐ What does it cost, and do you provide superbills?
☐ How do I reach you between visits, and how fast do you reply?
☐ Do you offer telehealth, and is there an in-person option?
☐ What happens if I need care urgently or after hours?
☐ How long is the wait for a first appointment?

7. How to make your first appointment count

A first psychiatric evaluation usually takes 60 to 90 minutes. Bring or prepare:

☐ Every medication and supplement you take, with doses
☐ Past psychiatric medications: what you took, for how long, what helped, and what didn't
☐ A short timeline: when symptoms started and what was happening in your life
☐ Family history of mental health conditions or substance use, if you know it
☐ Your honest alcohol, cannabis, and other substance use. It changes which treatments are safe.
☐ Recent lab work, and contact details for your primary care clinician and any therapist

☐ What a good outcome would look like for you, in a sentence

Expect questions about sleep, mood, energy, focus, safety, and your medical history. You should leave with a working diagnosis or a plan to clarify one, the options explained in plain language, and a follow-up plan. If you don't, ask.

If you need help now

- **988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988, any time, free and confidential
- **Emergency:** call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department
- **NAMI Chicago Helpline:** 833-NAMI-CHI (833-626-4244), call or text. Free help finding mental health resources in Chicago and suburban Cook County. Weekdays 9 a.m. to 8 p.m., weekends 9 a.m. to 5 p.m.

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